Suzanne's Diary for Nicholas

By James Patterson

MATTHEW: Hello, my sweet Nicholas, it's Dada. Have I told you how much I love you? Have I told you how precious you are to me? There---now I have. You are the best little boy, the best anyone could ever hope for. I love you so much. Yesterday morning something happened. And that's why I'm writing to you today instead of Mommy. Fathers and sons need to talk more than they do. A lot of us are so afraid to show our emotions, but I never want us to be like that. This is so hard, Nicky. It's the hardest thing I have ever had to say to anybody.

INTRODUCTION

Many families keep a journal of special events that occur in the lives of their child: A special book of memories . . . a tradition. In this selection we find Nicholas' father, Matthew logging his own personal entries in Suzanne's Diary to Nicholas by James Patterson

MATTHEW: Mommy was going to the store to the store to pick up your birthday present, your beautiful framed pictures. She was incredibly happy. She looked so pretty, deeply tanned and toned from all her walks on the beach. I remember seeing her leave, and I can't get that image out of my mind.

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Suzanne had such a beautiful smile on her face. She was dressed in a yellow jumper and gauzy white blouse. Her blond hair was full of curls and swung with her body as she walked. She was humming *your* song, "Whistle a Happy Tune."

I should have gone to her, should have kissed Suzanne good-bye, should have hugged her in my arms. But I just called, *"Love you,"* and since her hands were full, she blew me a kiss. *Oh, Nicky, Nicky, Nicky. How can I say this? How can I write these words?* Mommy had a heart attack on the way into town, sweet baby. Her heart, which was so big, so special in so many ways, could no longer hold out.

I was told that Suzanne was unconscious before she crashed into the guardrail on Old Pond Bridge Road. Her Jeep dropped into the water, landing on its side. I haven't gone to look at the actual scene of the accident. That is an image I don't need inside my head. What I can see is already is too much.

Dr. Cotter says that Suzanne died instantly after the massive coronary, But who really knows about those final seconds? I hope she didn't feel any pain. I hate to think that she did. It would be too cruel.

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She was unimaginably happy the last time I saw her. She looked so pretty, Nick. Oh God, I just want to see Suzanne one more time. Is that too much to ask? Is it unreasonable? It doesn't seem so to me. It's important to me that you know it wasn't Mommy's fault. She was such a safe driver; she would never have taken any chances. I always teased her about her driving.

She was the most generous-hearted person I have ever known, the most caring and compassionate. Maybe what I loved best about her was that she was a great, great listener. And she was funny. She would make a joke, right now. In know she would. And maybe she is. *Are you smiling now, Suzanne?* I'd like to think that you are I believe you must be.

I went today to the cemetery on Abel's Hill, to choose Mommy's special place. She was just thirty-seven when she died. How sad, how completely unthinkable to me, and to everyone else who knew her. What a shame; what a waste. Sometimes it makes me so angry. Tonight I sit in your nursery and watch your clown lamp throw happy shadows against the walls in the half-light. The oak rocking horse I made for you reminds me of the Flying Horses Carousel. Remember when we all went there on our vacation and rode the colorful horses? *Nicholas, Suzanne, and Matt.*

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I held you in front of me, and you loved to stroke the real horsehair mane. I can see Mommy riding ahead of us on National Velvet. She turns and there's that famous wink of hers.

MATTHEW: *Dear, sweet Nick,* I was startled out of my thoughts and reveries this afternoon by an unexpected phone call. *It was for Mommy.* Obviously someone had no idea what had happened, and for the first time, those strange and awful words passed through my lips like heavy weights: "Suzanne has passed away."

There was a long silence on the other end, followed by quiet apologies, and then nervous condolences. I was the man from the frame shop on the other side of the island, in Chilmark Center. Mommy had never made it there, and the pictures she had framed for you were still at the store. I told the shop owner that I would come around for the photos. Somehow, I would manage to do it.

I walk aimlessly from room to room, trying desperately to find a place where I can feel at peace with myself. Somehow, I always end up back in your room, sitting in the same rocker Mommy so often did when she talked to you and read to you and recited her goofy rhymes.

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And so I sit here now, looking at the pictures of us I finally picked up this afternoon. We are all sitting in front of the Flying Horses Carousel on a perfect, blue-skied afternoon.

You are wedged between us, Nick. Mommy has her arm around you and her legs crossed on mine. You're kissing Mommy, and I'm tickling you, and everyone is laughing, and it's just so beautiful. *Nicholas, Suzanne, and Matt----Forever One.*

I pull the cord on your music box in your crib, and it begins to play "Whistle a Happy Tune." I love this song, Nicky. I reach into the crib and I touch your sweet cheek. I tousle your golden blond hair, always so soft and fragrant. I wish I had listened to Mommy and never cut it.

I place an index finger in each of your small hands and let you squeeze. You're so strong buddy. I listen to your beautiful laugh, and it almost makes me laugh. "Whistle a Happy Tune" continues to play.

Oh my dear, darling little boy. I remember Mommy leaving on her errand that morning. I called out "I love you," and she blew me a kiss. Then she crinkled up her nose the way she does. You know what I mean. You know that look of hers. Then she gave me her "famous wink."

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Her arms were full, because she was carrying *you*, sweet baby. She wanted you to be the first to see the beautiful framed photographs. That's why she took you with her to town on your birthday morning. Suzanne carried you outside and carefully strapped you in your car seat. You were in the Jeep with Mommy when she crashed on the Old Pond Bridge Road. The two of you were together. I still can't bear to think about it.

I should've been there, Nicholas. I should've been there with you and Mommy! Maybe I could have helped: maybe I could have saved you somehow. At least I could have tried, and that would have meant everything to me.

But isn't it lucky that I knew you, held you and loved you, for the twelve months before God took you away? *Isn't it lucky that I got to know you, sweet little boy, my son?*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: James Patterson
ISBN: 978-0446611084
Publisher: Warner Books, Inc
Date: (Month/Year): July 2003

AWARDS

2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier